

Master Thesis Topic: GEO – Student Guide

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1. The topic in brief

Your thesis explores how companies can use Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) and its paid counterpart, Generative Engine Advertising (GEA), for international communication, lead generation and growth.

Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) means optimizing content so that it is cited, summarized or recommended in answers from ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Overviews/AI Mode, Claude and similar tools. The term comes from Aggarwal et al. (KDD 2024), who showed that adding statistics, quotations and authoritative citations can raise a source's visibility in generative answers.

Generative Engine Advertising (GEA) is the paid counterpart: sponsored placements inside or next to AI answers. Formats are new and differ strongly between platforms (OpenAI began testing ads in ChatGPT in 2026).

	Organic	Paid
Classic search	SEO: rank in a list of links; success = rank, click-through rate, traffic	SEA: keyword auctions; ads clearly separated from results
Generative search	GEO: be mentioned or cited inside one synthesized answer; success = citation frequency, share of voice, sentiment	GEA: ads woven into a conversational answer; open questions on labelling, prompt-based targeting, attribution

The key shift is the **zero-click problem**: traffic can fall while brand exposure rises, so clicks stop being the right outcome variable.

Why this matters now. AI answers are becoming a new front door to brands, yet most companies, especially SMEs and start-ups, have no strategy for it. Research and practice are moving fast but remain fragmented, so a structured synthesis with clear guidelines is valuable for firms and for research.

2. Research problem

Companies increasingly reach international customers through AI answers rather than search results, but it is unclear how MNEs, SMEs and start-ups can use GEO and GEA systematically for communication, lead generation and growth across markets.

Company type	Opportunity	Typical challenge
MNEs	Consistent, favourable brand presence in AI answers across markets and languages; reputation protection	Balancing global and local content; different AI platforms dominate in different countries
SMEs	Compete with larger brands, since AI answers cite expertise rather than ad budgets; enter foreign markets	Limited resources and know-how; low brand awareness abroad
Start-ups	Be recommended early in new categories; efficient lead generation; category creation	No track record or third-party mentions yet; speed vs. credibility

The thesis looks at three uses:

- **Communication:** brand positioning and reputation, being cited and described favourably in AI answers.
- **Lead generation:** appearing when buyers ask AI tools for suppliers, products or solutions, in B2C and B2B.
- **Growth in international business:** entering new markets, adapting to languages and cultures, scaling visibility abroad.

Guiding research question: How can companies (MNEs, SMEs, start-ups) use GEO and GEA for international communication, lead generation and growth?

Possible sub-questions:

1. What do academic research and practice currently know about GEO/GEA success factors?
2. Which best practices emerge from companies that are already visible in AI answers?
3. How do requirements differ by firm type and across international markets?
4. Which guidelines can be derived, and how well do they work for a real company?

3. What your thesis must deliver

The thesis combines a synthesis of existing knowledge with a practical application in five building blocks:

1. **Taking stock of academic knowledge:** a structured review of research on GEO, GEA, AI search and the zero-click shift.
2. **Taking stock of practical knowledge:** practitioner reports, industry studies, tool providers and expert voices, critically weighed against the academic evidence.
3. **Best practice examples:** analyse several companies that use GEO/GEA successfully, ideally a mix of MNEs, SMEs and start-ups from different markets. What do they do, and why does it work?
4. **Guidelines:** derive a practical, step-by-step framework for companies, differentiated by firm type and international context.
5. **Application to a real-world example:** apply your guidelines to one real company, for example an SME or start-up going international. Assess its current visibility in AI answers, identify gaps and give concrete recommendations.

The application makes the thesis distinctive. Ideally, choose a company you can access, such as your employer, an internship company, a family business or a start-up.

4. Thesis structure and quality criteria

Chapter	Content	Approx. share
1. Introduction	Problem, relevance for international business, research question, structure	10%
2. Foundations	From SEO/SEA to GEO/GEA; how AI answers select sources; relevance for MNEs, SMEs and start-ups	15%
3. State of knowledge	Academic and practical knowledge on GEO/GEA for communication, lead generation and growth	20%
4. Best practice examples	Comparative analysis of selected companies	15%
5. Guidelines	Framework derived from chapters 3 and 4	15%
6. Real-world application	Guidelines applied to one company; recommendations	20%
7. Conclusion	Summary, implications, limitations, outlook	5%

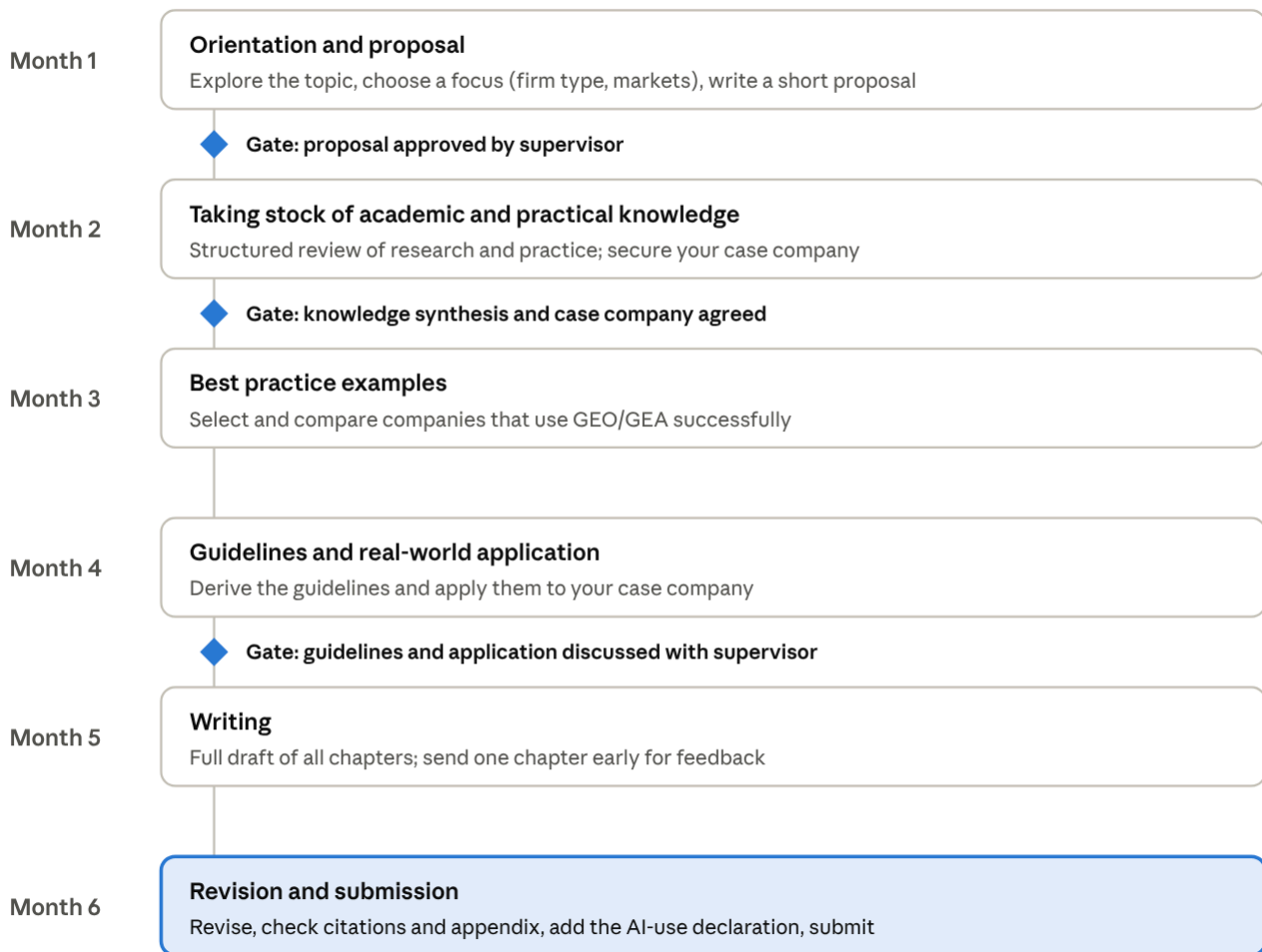
What a strong thesis shows

- A clear link between GEO/GEA and international business: markets, languages, firm type.
- A critical, balanced synthesis rather than a summary of blog posts; academic and practitioner knowledge kept apart and weighed.
- Best practice examples selected with explicit criteria and compared systematically.
- Guidelines that follow logically from the evidence and are concrete enough for a manager to use.
- An application that tests the guidelines on a real company and reflects on what worked and what did not.

5. Timeline and supervision

Plan for about six months; the three gates are fixed meetings where you only move on once your supervisor agrees.

Six months from proposal to submission, with three supervisor gates



thesis roadmap · 6 phases, 3 supervisor gates

The real-world application needs access to a company, so secure your case company by the end of month 2.

How supervision works

- Meet roughly every 3–4 weeks; send a one-page update (done, next, questions) two working days before each meeting.
- Bring decisions, not just status: e.g. "I propose these five best practice companies because...".
- Agree on the case company and the selection criteria for best practice examples with your supervisor before you start the analysis.
- Guest input is possible: practitioners such as Thomas Peham (OtterlyAI) or researchers such as Erik Hermann may be approached for interviews or expert feedback, after agreeing this with your supervisor.

6. Express your interest

Interested? Email Arne.Floh@wu.ac.at within one week, by Oct 12, 2026 .

In your email, include:

- Your name, student ID and master programme
- Why the topic interests you (3–5 sentences)
- The firm type and markets you would like to focus on
- A possible company for the real-world application, if you already have one
- Your planned start and submission dates